MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 2: From Elizabethan to Metaphysical Poetry

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Poetry from Spenser and Sidney to Donne and Herbert connects literary form with love, religion, courtly life, and the poet's social role.

Start with a picture

Think of two ways to discuss love. One builds a beautifully arranged garden of praise. Another starts an argument and compares love to a scientific instrument. Both can express intense feeling, but their methods lead readers through different kinds of thought.

These are helpful pictures, not rigid definitions. Elizabethan and metaphysical writing overlap and contain many variations.

1. Literary form does social work

A **form** is a way of organising writing, such as a sonnet, pastoral, or epic. Choosing a form can also suggest who the poet wants to be and whom the poem addresses.

Think of choosing between a personal letter, a public speech, and a national anthem. Each has different expectations and a different relationship with an audience.

2. Spenser builds a public literary identity

The unit links three kinds of writing with different roles:

Form and example	Role or possibility
Pastoral: The Shepheardes Calender	Participation in a community of poets
Epic: The Faerie Queene	Moral and political counsel, national ambition
Love lyric: Amoretti	Presentation of personal desire within literary form

Spenser's career helps show how literature, national identity, patronage, and ambition interact. A **patron** is someone whose support can help a writer's work or career.

3. Prothalamion joins private and public worlds

Its riverside setting and nymphs suggest pastoral. Its wedding subject suggests lyric celebration. Its movement towards London and its courtly connections place that celebration within a public world.

The speaker's personal disappointment is not sealed away from the poem's social purpose. Both coexist in the writing.

4. Sidney: love poetry and courtly pressures

Sidney was a courtier as well as a writer. *Astrophil and Stella* can be read through love, poetic ambition, self-examination, and the pressures of public duty.

The lover's obedience, frustration, hope, and rejection can resemble the courtier's dependence on a powerful superior. This is a possible interpretive relationship, not proof that every love line secretly names a political event.

The Sidney circle, including Mary Sidney, also shows how literary culture develops through communities and networks rather than isolated genius alone.

5. Ask whose desire the poem centres

A sonnet may give detailed access to a male speaker's feelings while giving the beloved less space to speak. Ask whether the woman appears as a full person or mainly as the object of his desire.

Calling a poem sincere does not make its gender relationships neutral. A persuasive speaker can still be partial or self-interested.

6. What changes with metaphysical poetry?

Donne and other writers often bring conversational energy, argumentative structure, paradox, and surprising comparisons into poetry. Thought and feeling operate together.

In *The Canonization*, religious language magnifies human love. In *A Valediction*, a compass explains unity across separation. Herbert makes devotion a space for formal experiment, including the visual design of *Easter Wings*.

Metaphysical poetry is not simply "difficult poetry," nor does it mean the poets all held the same beliefs.

7. The label has a history

Later critics helped establish "metaphysical" as a category. Some criticised the poets' strained comparisons; later readers admired their intellectual energy. A literary label is therefore also part of the history of criticism.

Build an exam answer

Compare selected features, not entire ages as stereotypes. For example: Spenser’s public literary roles; Sidney’s tensions between desire and duty; Donne’s argumentative conceits; Herbert’s devotional experiments. Include continuity as well as change.

Quick check

1. Is poetic form only decoration? **No; it can organise thought and signal social roles.**
2. What is patronage? **Support that helps a writer’s career or work.**
3. Does a male speaker’s account fully reveal the beloved’s feelings? **Not necessarily.**
4. Are emotion and intelligence opposites in metaphysical poetry? **No; they often work together.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Discuss the interaction of poetic form, social identity, and desire in Elizabethan and metaphysical poetry.

Expanded discussion

Elizabethan poetic forms can be read as ways of creating a public identity as well as organising language. Spenser’s pastoral, epic, and lyric writing associates the poet with different roles: participant in a literary community, counsellor on moral and national questions, and speaker of personal desire. Form therefore helps establish a relationship between a writer, a tradition, and an audience. It cannot be understood as ornament alone.

Sidney’s position reveals a related tension between literary activity and courtly life. Astrophil’s language of service, frustration, and dependence can invite comparison with the courtier’s relation to authority. Love poetry also creates a space for self-examination, but the speaker’s sincerity should not be confused with complete access to the beloved’s perspective. Questions of gender emerge when a poem presents female identity mainly through the needs and feelings of a male speaker.

Metaphysical poetry develops especially striking ways of making emotion think. Donne’s conceits organise arguments through comparisons that initially seem remote from love. A compass, for instance, can turn physical distance into a model of continuing connection. Herbert’s formal experiments bring devotional experience into an equally inventive relationship with structure. These examples challenge the assumption that intellectual complexity weakens emotional sincerity.

The distinction between Elizabethan and metaphysical writing remains useful if treated as a flexible critical tool. There are continuities in rhetoric, religious concern, patronage, and the exploration of desire. Later critics also shaped the category “metaphysical,” sometimes condemning features that other readers would admire. A mature account should therefore analyse particular methods while avoiding a rigid story in which one age simply replaces another.

Suggested answer structure

1. Form and public role
2. Spenser’s three genres
3. Sidney: court, desire, and gender
4. Donne and Herbert: argument and experiment
5. Continuities and the history of critical labels

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not reduce Elizabethan poetry to emotion and metaphysical poetry to intelligence. Both involve crafted language, feeling, and thought.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Concepts to add to the comparison

Courtly literary culture involved manuscript circulation, patronage, friendships, and institutions as well as individual inspiration. Mary Sidney’s literary activity and the Sidney circle help show that the Royal Court was not the only centre of cultural energy. The “public” and “private” are therefore related categories, not sealed containers.

The beloved in a sonnet may have great symbolic power while receiving little independent speech. Analyse the difference between being important to the speaker and having a perspective the poem actually presents. This is a stronger argument than merely declaring the poetry sincere or insincere.

Dryden and Johnson helped make “metaphysical” a critical category, often through objections to excessive intellectual ingenuity or unlike ideas forced together. Later appreciation changed the evaluation of such methods. A historical account of the label must distinguish the poets’ writing from the judgements subsequently made about it. Do not treat a later critical label as the name of a formally organised school with a single manifesto.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Explore how the use of form is connected to Edmund Spenser’s role as ‘national poet’.
2. How does Sir Philip Sidney engage with the contradictions between desire and duty in Astrophil and Stella?
3. Examine the role of metaphysical poetry in challenging the poetic conventions of the Elizabethan era.

4. Discuss Spenser’s “Prothalamion” by focussing on its themes and form.